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cally acknowledged as the single biggest factor in the Mahayuti's victory. It benefited more than 23 million women in the state, claimed the Mahayuti, and promised to scale it up to Rs 2,100 if elected. Buying into that promise, the women voted with their feet, their turnout higher than men's in at least 15 constituencies.

Other schemes like stipends for apprentices, a waiver on the toll levied at the five entry points to Mumbai, and pure doles like free visits to pilgrimage centres, proved force multipliers. As did the promise of hiking the annual payout for farmers under the Namo Shetkari Mahasanman Nidhi Yojana from Rs 12,000 to Rs 15,000, to address agrarian distress. The sops were meant to take some of the sting out of the farmers' anger, particularly the soybean and cotton cultivators in Marathwada and Vidarbha, upset with the poor rates for their produce.

But what promises to be a boon for the electorate could well turn into a curse for the government. The per capita top-ups for the Ladki Bahin and farmers' schemes—of Rs 600 monthly and Rs 3,000 annually, respectively, not counting farm loan waivers—will strain the state exchequer even further. Maharashtra's debt burden is already 18 per cent of the state GDP; it has to meet a debt and interest servicing burden of around Rs 4.6 lakh crore by 2029. Welfarism cannot come at the cost of growth and development in a state seen as the country's financial powerhouse.

The Other Challenges

Another arena where the competing ambitions of the forces within the Mahayuti as well as outside will play out is the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), elections to which are long overdue. Whoever controls the BMC is said to control Mumbai. Traditionally, the Sena's control over the cash-rich corporation has helped it foster an enviable "reward economy" that lubricated its once-formidable organisational machinery. "The BJP and Shinde will be locked in an internecine war to control the BMC," says a career bureaucrat.

Then, there is the unresolved Maratha question, even if the threat from their disenchantment did not crystallise into an anti-vote this time. The agitation led by Manoj Jarange-Patil for Marathas to have a share of the OBC reservation pie had led to the MVA winning seven out of eight Lok Sabha seats in the Marathwada region this summer. But while it worked in the general election where the fight was bipolar, the presence of multiple Maratha candidates in the assembly contest left the voters confused. While Jarange-Patil did call for the "oppressors" of Marathas—read by most to mean the BJP—to be defeated, he did not specify who the community should vote for, foreclosing the possibility of tactical voting.

Assembly polls done, the next battle will be for control of the BMC. Whoever runs the cash-rich corporation controls Mumbai

But while the BJP's reverse mobilisation of the OBCs opposed to Maratha hegemony may have helped the Mahayuti neutralise the dominant community, Maratha dominance over state politics endures, as analyst Somnath Gholve points out. The community still has the largest number of MLAs. The government, says political analyst Abhay Deshpande, will have to ensure that the legislation on Maratha quota (which granted the community 10 per cent ring-fenced quotas in education and jobs) clears the legal test, failing which there could be a fresh round of agitations.

Trouble could also erupt from among the Dalits. Following the Supreme Court order allowing state governments to sub-categorise the Scheduled Castes (SCs) for the purpose of reservations, Maharashtra set up a committee to examine the issue. The Hindu SCs, who consolidated in favour of the Mahayuti this time, complain that the more militant Buddhist Dalits (mostly erstwhile Mahars who converted to Buddhism with Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar in 1956) have cornered most of the benefits and the Dalit socio-political space. But any sub-categorisation may upset the Buddhist Dalits, who are vocal about their demands. Likewise, the government will have to strike a balance between the competing demands of different communities, particularly the powerful Dhangar (shepherd) cohort, which is part of the OBC category yet clamouring for inclusion among Scheduled Tribes, a move other tribals resent.

An Alliance in Disarray

Now that the worst has come to pass, what will become of the MVA? With Ajit's NCP and the Shinde Sena stealing a march over the parent camps, the Sena(UBT) and the NCP(SCP) will have trouble keeping their flock together. Already, NCP minister Anil Bhaidas Patil has claimed that NCP(SCP) MLAs are in touch with them, while former Sena MP Rahul Shewale says that Uddhav's MPs and MLAs may join them gradually. This is also likely to cast a shadow over the political future of Uddhav and Pawar's chosen heirs—Aaditya and Supriya.

The Uddhav Sena is also staring at a vertical split in its core vote base. "Our Marathi vote base overlaps with that of the Shinde Sena, BJP and MNS," says